

C9. Creating content, tracking it, and studying social media audiences



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1. Why do people share?



The background is a solid red color covered with a dense, chaotic pattern of black hand-drawn geometric shapes. These shapes include various line segments, circles, triangles, rectangles, and wavy lines, creating a textured, abstract effect.

Spreadability
Contagiousness
Viralization



Exercise: why we distribute content on social media

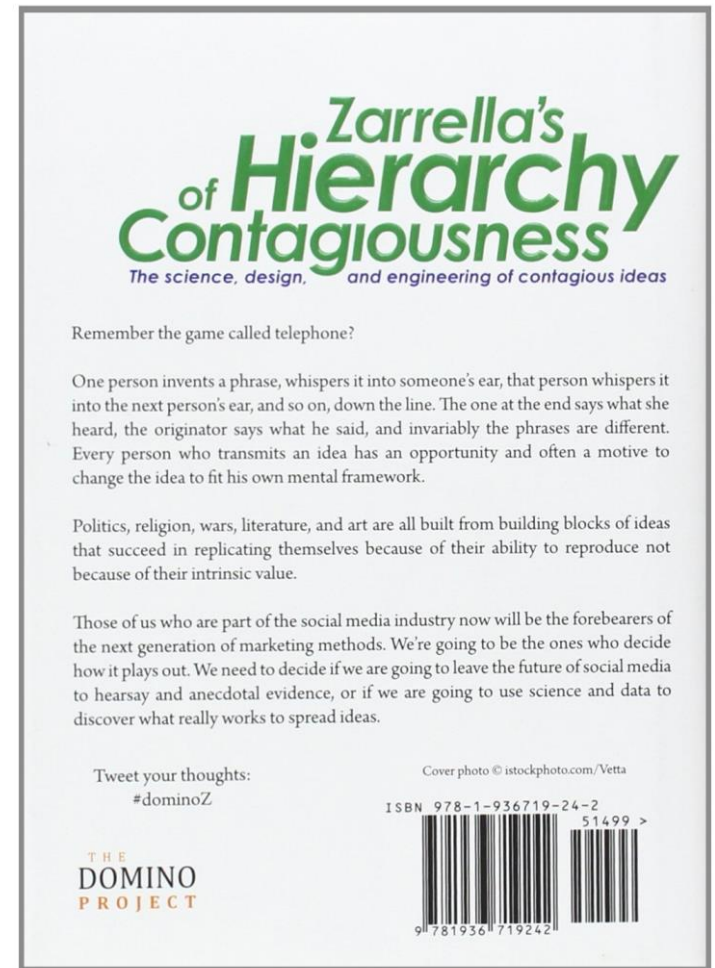
A. Think about the content you've recently shared or articles you've recently clicked on.

B. Check the Social Media apps on your phones for content feeds and identify examples of content you have recently interacted with.

Reflect on what motivates you to share content. or interact with it.

Zarella (2011) - Zarella's Hierarchy of Contagiousness: The Science, Design, and Engineering of Contagious Ideas

- Three contagiousness criteria:
 - a)Exposure: People must be exposed to your content.
 - b)Attention: They need to be aware of the content you want to spread, such as headlines/topics and more attractive status updates.
 - c)Motivation: call to action - experiment to determine what works and what doesn't work so well.
- Some types of information are easier to spread than others. Conditions:
 - People must be keen for information.
 - You need to know what information people already have and what they lack.
 - You need to understand what moves them - their hopes, their fears, their animosities.
 - You need to have an understanding of how they deal with their hopes, fears, animosities and so on.
- Among the reasons people are motivated to spread others' content/ideas are: personal relevance, humour, usefulness, and shared common interest.

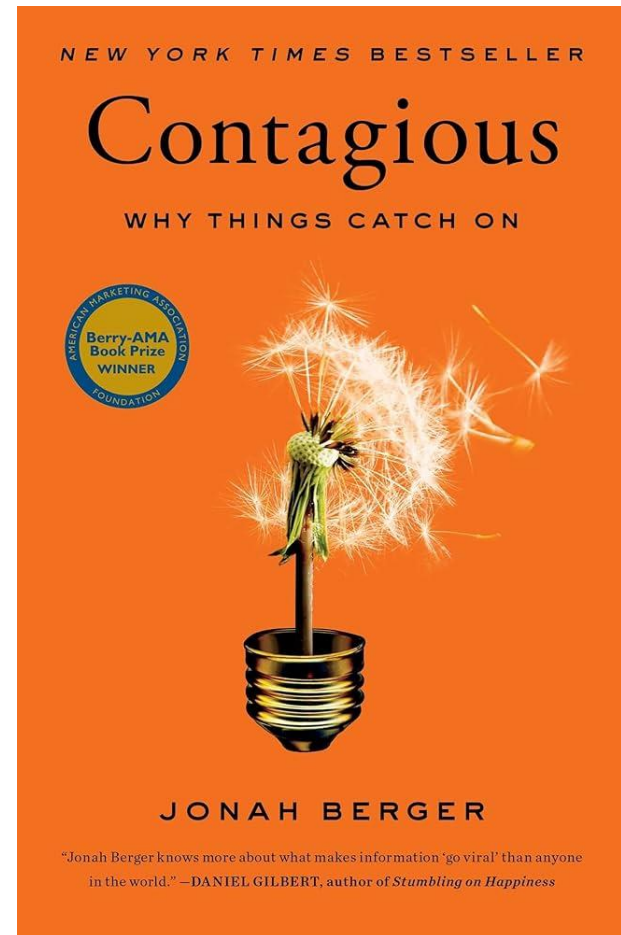


Berger (2013): Contagious: Why things catch on

• 5 principles:

- Social currency: we share things that make us look good
- Triggers: Information that's easy to remember means it's top of mind and on the tip of your tongue.
- Emotion: When we care, we share.
- Public visibility: Built to show, built to grow.
- Practical Value: News that people can use.
- Stories: People are natural storytellers, and all great brands learn to tell stories. Information travels in the form of idle chatter.

See also Moss's article(6.12.2022) „ Social Media Sharing: The Psychology of Why We Share”-
<https://everyonesocial.com/blog/the-psychology-of-how-and-why-we-share/>



If you want to see Berger's presentation in extenso „Contagious: Why Things Catch On”, see:
<https://youtu.be/rLcEcOlgz9A> (50:32 min)

6 Reasons Things Go Viral – Contagious: Why Things Catch On by Jonah Berger

https://youtu.be/HfSs_hOAKzY





WHY PEOPLE

Share

The Psychology of Social Sharing



Entertainment

49% say sharing allows them to inform others of products they care about and potentially change opinions or encourage action.



Define Ourselves

68% share to give people a better sense of who they are and what they care about.



78%

Relationships

78% share information online because it lets them stay connected to people they may not otherwise stay in touch with.



69%

Self-Fulfillment

69% share information because it allows them to feel more involved in the world.



84%

Support A Cause

84% share because it is a way to support causes or issues they care about.

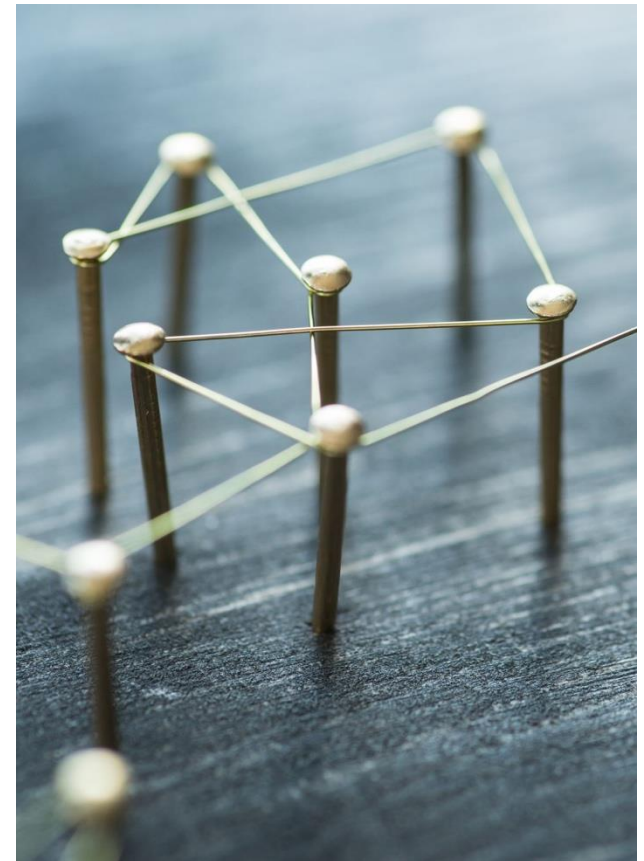
Berger and Milkman (2012)

- analysed articles in the New York Times over a three-month period to identify which types of articles were distributed most often and why.
 - They examined each article to identify the emotions the article evoked.
 - While articles that evoked positive emotions were shared more than negative ones on average, negative emotions, such as anxiety and anger, increased sharing.
- There are certain types of emotions with high arousal, whether positive or negative, that compel sharing.
- Sadness is a low arousal emotion.
 - Awe (amazement), anger and anxiety are high-arousal emotions.



Why do people spread fake news?(Talwar et al. 2019)

- Online trust, self-disclosure, FoMO (fear of missing out) and social media fatigue have been positively associated with the distribution of fake news.
- In terms of online social comparison, there was a negative association with fake news dissemination.
- Self-disclosure and social media fatigue were positively associated with checking the authenticity of news before sharing it.
- Online trust was negatively associated with verifying the authenticity of news before sharing.



Needs and uses

- Needs: emotional, social, cognitive and habitual (Wang et al., 2012).
- Unmet needs may accumulate and generate more intensive use of social networks in the future (Wang et al., 2012).
- Facebook use is driven by the need for self-presentation and the need to belong (Nadkarni and Hofmann, 2012).
- Users engage in continuous impression management (how they are perceived from the outside) , being encouraged by the positive feedback they receive, which is associated with a positive online self-presentation (Metzler and Scheithauer, 2017).

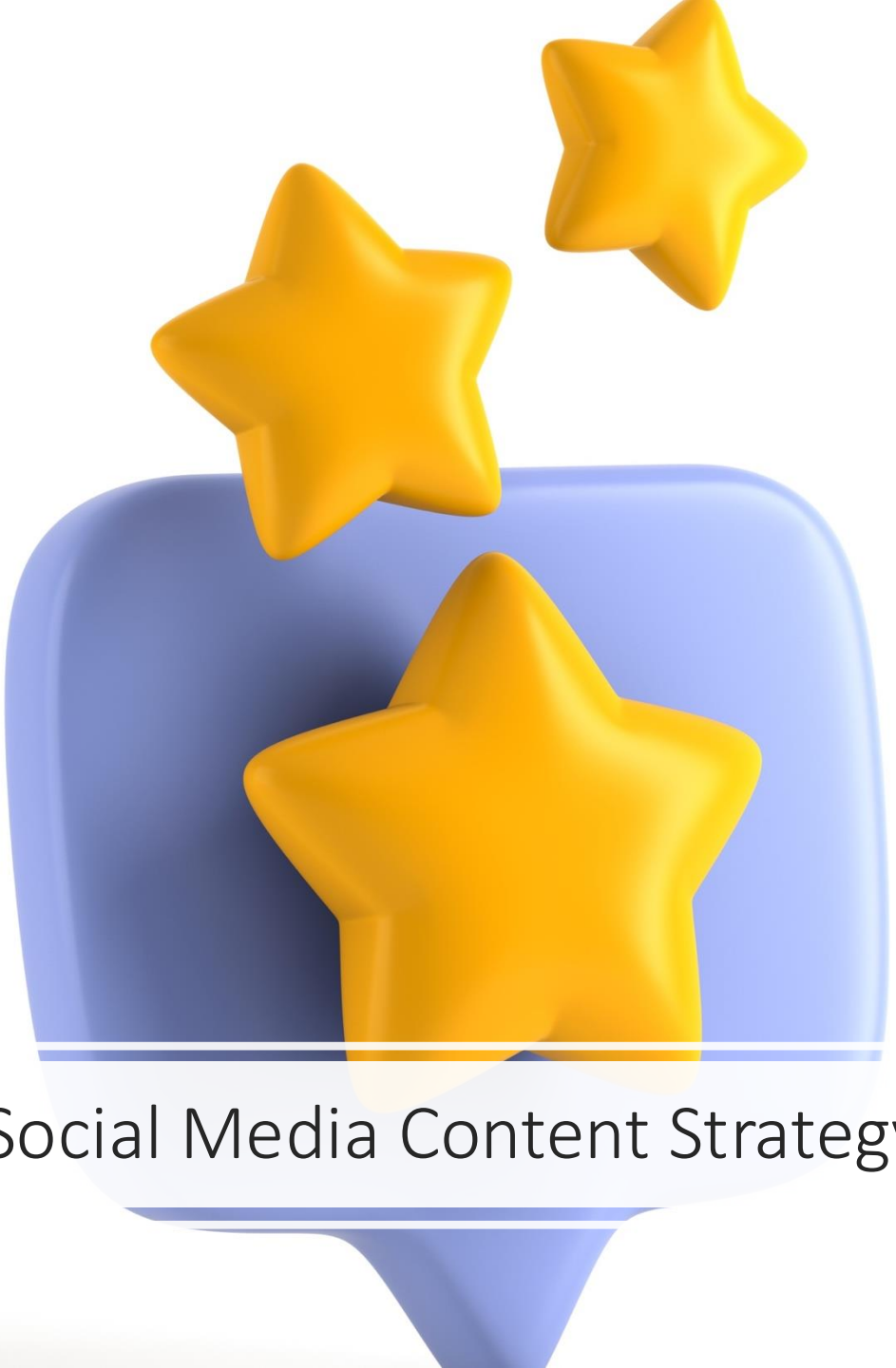


Quesenberry and Coolsen (2019)

- examined the text of posts that brands made on their Facebook pages to see what content increased likes, shares, comments and, ultimately, organic reach.
- Since organic reach for Facebook page content has declined in recent years, it's important to figure out what type of content users are willing to share because Facebook's algorithm is more likely to give us content that our friends engage with.
- Conducted a content analysis of the text in 1,000 Facebook brand posts to find out what increases engagement metrics that drive organic reach (e.g. likes, shares, comments)
- focused on 18 variables: Aspects of posts such as photos and links, character and word length, number of hashtags, number of links and number of brand mentions, content of posts - new/current style posts, posts focused on promotions or pricing, contests and sweepstakes, posts, posts on corporate social responsibility (CSR) and social causes, events, celebrity-focused posts, questions, calls to action, posts that used exclamation points, fan contests and user-generated content, educational posts, and posts highlighting specific times or dates.
- They found that: brand posts on Facebook that indicated something was new received more shares and comments. Posts that emphasized a date or time, such as a deadline to complete an action, received more shares. Educational posts, on the other hand, received fewer likes and comments. Interestingly, promotional posts, contest posts and posts related to social or CSR causes were not associated with any of the three engagement metrics: shares, likes and comments.

Shahbaznezhad, H., Dolan, R., & Rashidirad, M. (2021). The Role of Social Media Content Format and Platform in Users' Engagement Behavior. *Journal of Interactive Marketing*, 53(1), 47-65. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.intmar.2020.05.001>

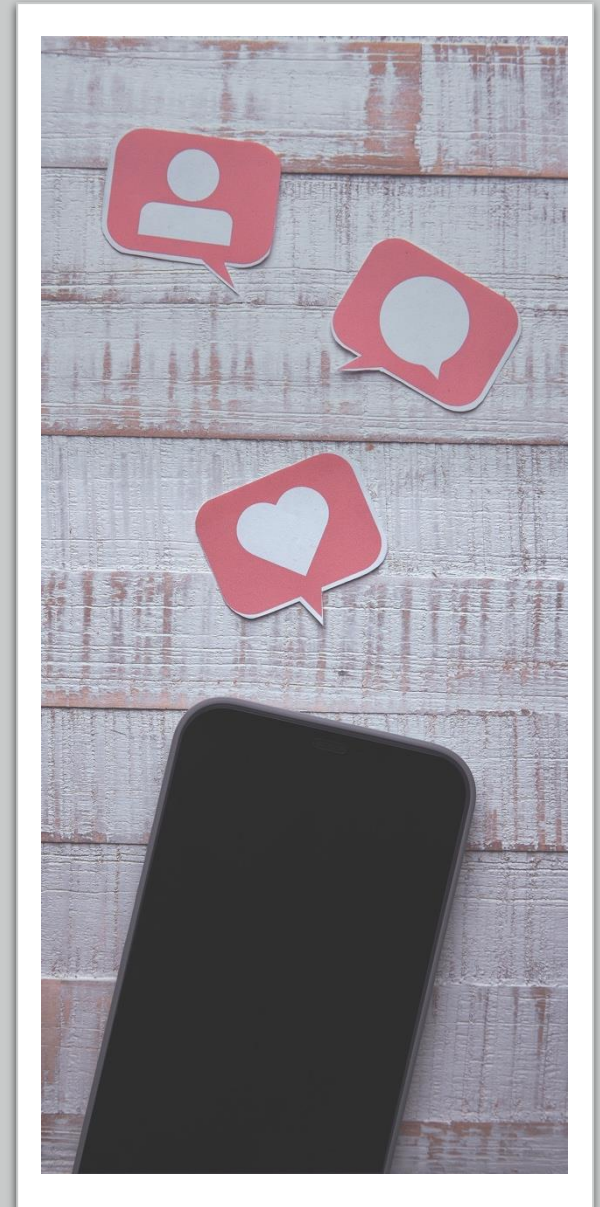
- The level of engagement varies from simple types of engagement (e.g., "liking" a post on Instagram) to larger types of customer engagement in co-creation activities (e.g., posting reviews).
- Instagram users (fans) appear to be more passively engaged, compared to Facebook fans, who tend to demonstrate more active behaviour in the form of comments → Facebook can typically be used on a desktop device versus the mobile app, allowing users to more easily type comments compared to those on their phone → if a goal of social media content is to collect rich feedback through comments and discussion, this finding suggests that Facebook may be a more suitable platform.
- When posting content strategically, using the 'photo' format will generate significantly more likes than comments. This can be a powerful tool for boosting the 'virality' of a post, inspiring social media managers to consider the impact of visual content on engagement.
- In the case of emotional content, the use of video format will stimulate active user engagement (in the form of comments). Travel companies that might want to communicate a strong emotional message and get active engagement (comments) should, therefore, use videos in their content.
- The number of comments on a post and the sentiment of these comments significantly boost the number of likes on the post → positive and active engagement in the form of comments increases the continued virality of the post in the form of likes.
- Fans tend to express their opinion and write more comments with a negative sentiment than a positive one. Managers, as well as researchers, need to better understand the implications of negative comments and word-of-mouth on social media platforms, as this could be potentially damaging to a brand.



Social Media Content Strategy

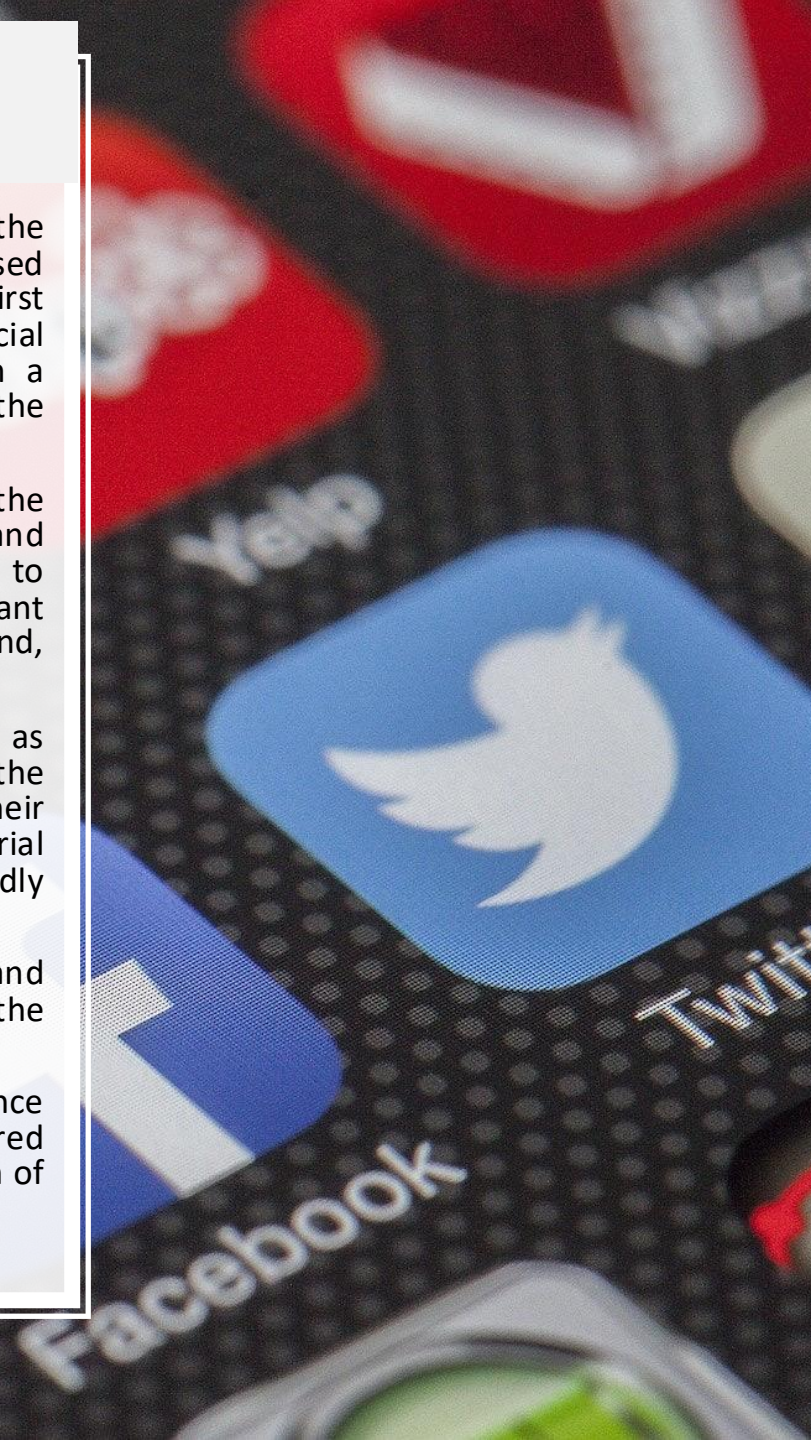
Content creators

- The term content creator is defined as "the marketing and professionalization of native social media users who generate and distribute original content in close interaction and engagement with their communities on mainstream social media platforms as well as offline" (Cunningham and Craig, 2021, p. 1).
- Creators are now nicknamed in many ways: influencers, bloggers and vloggers, gamers, live streamers, camgirls, broadcast jockeys (Korea) and, in China, KOLs (key opinion leaders), Zhuo and wanghong, among others.
- They can also be referred to according to the platform used - eng. YouTubers, tweeters (Twitter), grammars (Instagram) and snappers (Snapchat).
- Researchers have also used other terms such as micro-celebrities (Abidin, 2016),
- many SM content creators have gone on to develop greater cultural influence than many 'mainstream' celebrities (actors, painters, sculptors, TV people and so on): e.g., Huda Beauty (Dubai), Chiara Ferragni (Italy), PewDiePie (UK), Ninja (US).



The power of social media platforms

- This focus on platforms represents a significant shift from the relatively decentralised online ecosystem that characterised Western digital media from the late 1990s to the middle of the first decade of this century, in which a variety of competing social networking services and DIY websites or blogs coexisted on a single, common platform (the World Wide Web), itself built on the public Internet.
- The digital evolution that has been achieved by expanding the reach and connections between social media platforms and creating data streams and interfaces with other websites has led to "the rise of [the] [digital] platform [model] as the dominant infrastructural and economic model of the social web" (Helmond, 2015, p. 1).
- This 'platformisation' signifies not only that platforms such as YouTube, Facebook, or Instagram have great power in the information and creative content industries but also that their logic—their mode of operation and their value systems (editorial politics)—are reshaping society and culture more profoundly (Burgess 2015; Cunningham and Craig, 2021).
- Content creators have played a major role in building cultures and audiences on platforms, but it is also true that platforms have the power to transform or disrupt the careers of creators.
- Platform logics shape what counts as value (for example, audience attention or engagement) and how that value is measured (whether by clicks, subscriptions, viewing time, or a combination of these).



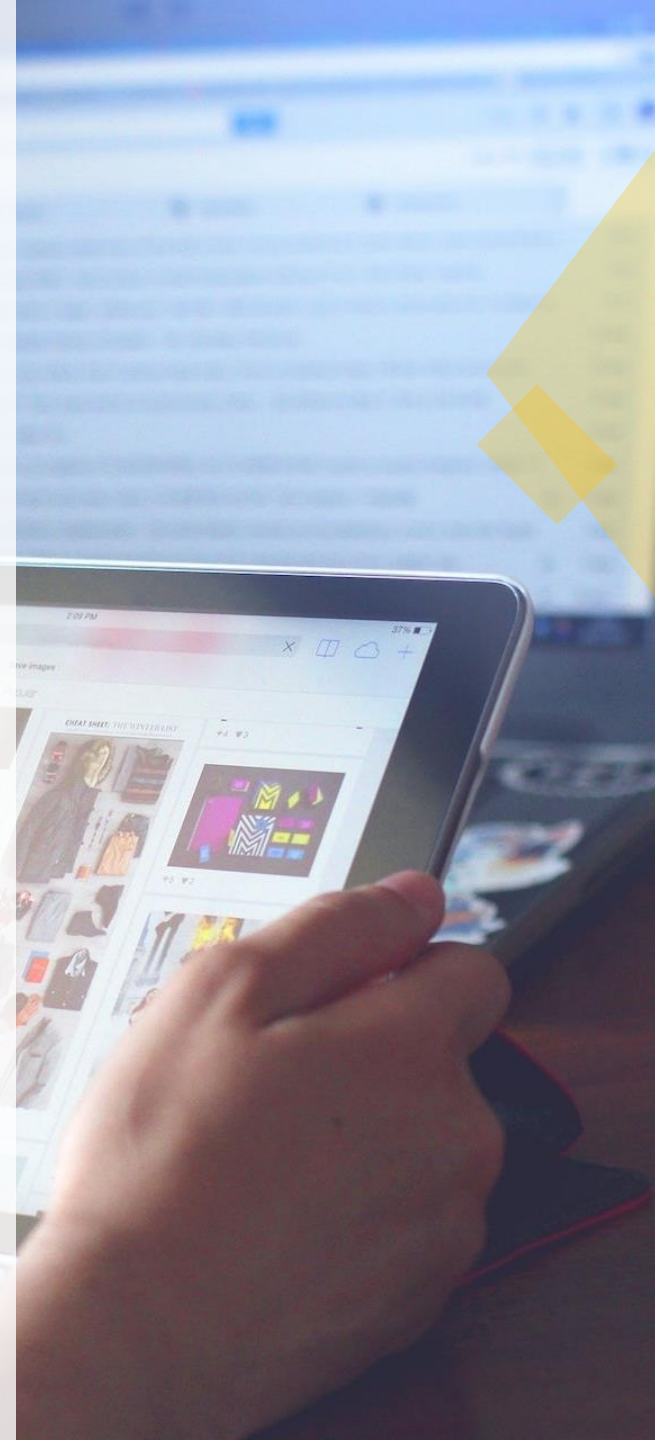


The power of social media platforms

- Due to their ability to create communities where users feel more connected to influencers through higher levels of engagement, authenticity, and trustworthiness, social media celebrities have an advantage when it comes to promoting products: social media celebrities' degree of influence on consumers is higher due to more effective audience penetration and more effective influence to buy (Nouri, 2018).
- Substantially captures consumers' attention and spending to drive higher sales and draw more attention to brands
- Current trends in corporate social media platforms (e.g., Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, TikTok, Youtube) have been to adopt a much less open and centralized approach to innovation geared towards a policy of growing user data markets, which has made open access to data less applicable.
- because of their cultural power, their role in extreme discourses, and the rise of far-right subcultures, as well as growing concerns about the exploitation of user data for commercial purposes without regard for privacy, SM platforms should be carefully studied and scrutinised (not only by researchers but also by authorities)

Recommendations for content creation

- Content creation should take into account the specifics of the audience, the specifics of the platform and, of course, the proposed communication objectives (of the company or the content creator)
- Adapting to the audience's requirements is a data-driven process. It involves using our insights about the audience and the current digital trends provided by SM monitoring companies like Hootsuite and We Are Social.
- Adaptation to platform specifics: platform policy (terms and conditions, editorial policy), platform functions and features and specific content trends.
- Other rules: specific digital copywriting rules (see: [10 Copywriting Tips to Rock Your Digital Marketing](#) și [What Is SEO Copywriting?](#))





YouTube

- YouTube policy:
 - Terms and conditions:
<https://www.youtube.com/static?&template=terms>
 - YouTube policies:
https://support.google.com/youtube/topic/2803176?hl=en&ref_topic=6151248
 - YouTube's Community Guidelines:
<https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/9288567>

See: <https://youtu.be/PO5z1bqW5yY>

- For creating content:
<https://www.youtube.com/creators/>

A close-up, slightly blurred image of the Facebook logo (a white 'f' on a blue square) and the word 'Facebook' in white text on a blue background, positioned on the left side of the slide.

Facebook

- Terms: <https://www.facebook.com/terms.php>
- **Meta Business Suite:**
<https://www.facebook.com/business/learn/lessons/creator-studio-overview>
- Basic guide for content creators:
<https://www.facebook.com/business/learn/series/content-creators>



TikTok

- <https://creatormarketplace.tiktok.com>
- Terms and conditions:
<https://www.tiktok.com/community-guidelines?lang=ro-RO>



Instagram

- Community rules:
<https://help.instagram.com/477434105621119#>
- Terms of use:
https://help.instagram.com/581066165581870/?helpref=hc_fnav
- Meta Platform Terms
<https://developers.facebook.com/terms>
- Help Center(Instagram features, Privacy, security reporting, staying safe)
<https://help.instagram.com/1417489251945243/?helpref=breadcrumb>



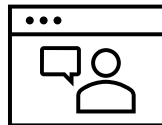
Homework:

Based on the materials outlined here about Facebook, YouTube, Instagram and TikTok's content and usage policies, answer the following questions:

- ? What are the main rules of use of the four platforms presented?
- ? What types of content can be uploaded to these platforms?
- ? What control strategies do these platforms apply to uploaded content? Who monitors (supervises) the uploaded content?
- ? Why are certain types of content removed from these platforms? Which types of content are removed?
- ? Can the content be monetised on these platforms? How?

Social Media Audiences

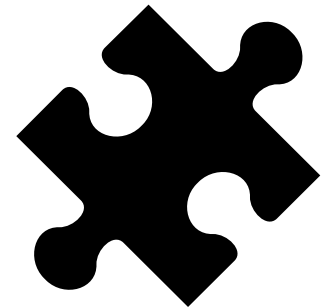
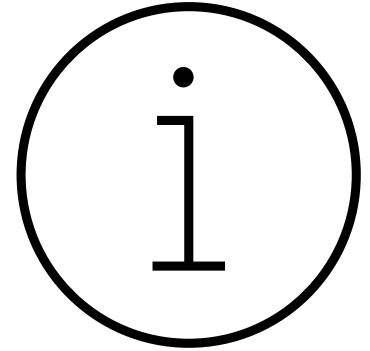
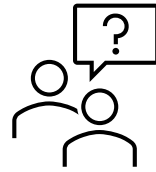
- Audiences in social media are actively making their presence felt by shaping media streams, and brand producers and managers, as well as corporate communicators, are hard at work serving business needs, listening and responding to audience requests/feedback in a timely, active way (Jenkins, 2013, p. 2).
- Audience segmentation - audience segmentation
- Demographic, psychographic



- <https://youtu.be/91D5hjMEADg?si=kzEeBAfVgBDgOdHW>
- <https://youtu.be/7ITff1flbSc?si=Z8mlwONIGE48dpO1>

What we should know (?)

- What interests and consumption behaviour does the social media audience engage in?
- Whether the segmentation is appropriate to the proposed communication/promotion/campaign objectives
- How the audience reacts to our messages, but to other messages (competitors' messages)
- Understanding the audience helps us establish perspectives and how we will act—what we should do and, mainly, what we should not do related to the audience.
- Do we have the ability to measure the audience effectively?



Content on Social Media Platforms

- Content on social media platforms reflects the individual's online identity and provides factual data about the individual.
- <https://hbr.org/2016/08/to-get-more-out-of-social-media-think-like-an-anthropologist>
- In an effective communication process, you need to understand your audience/dialogue partner.
- Listen and understand
- Social Media Listening

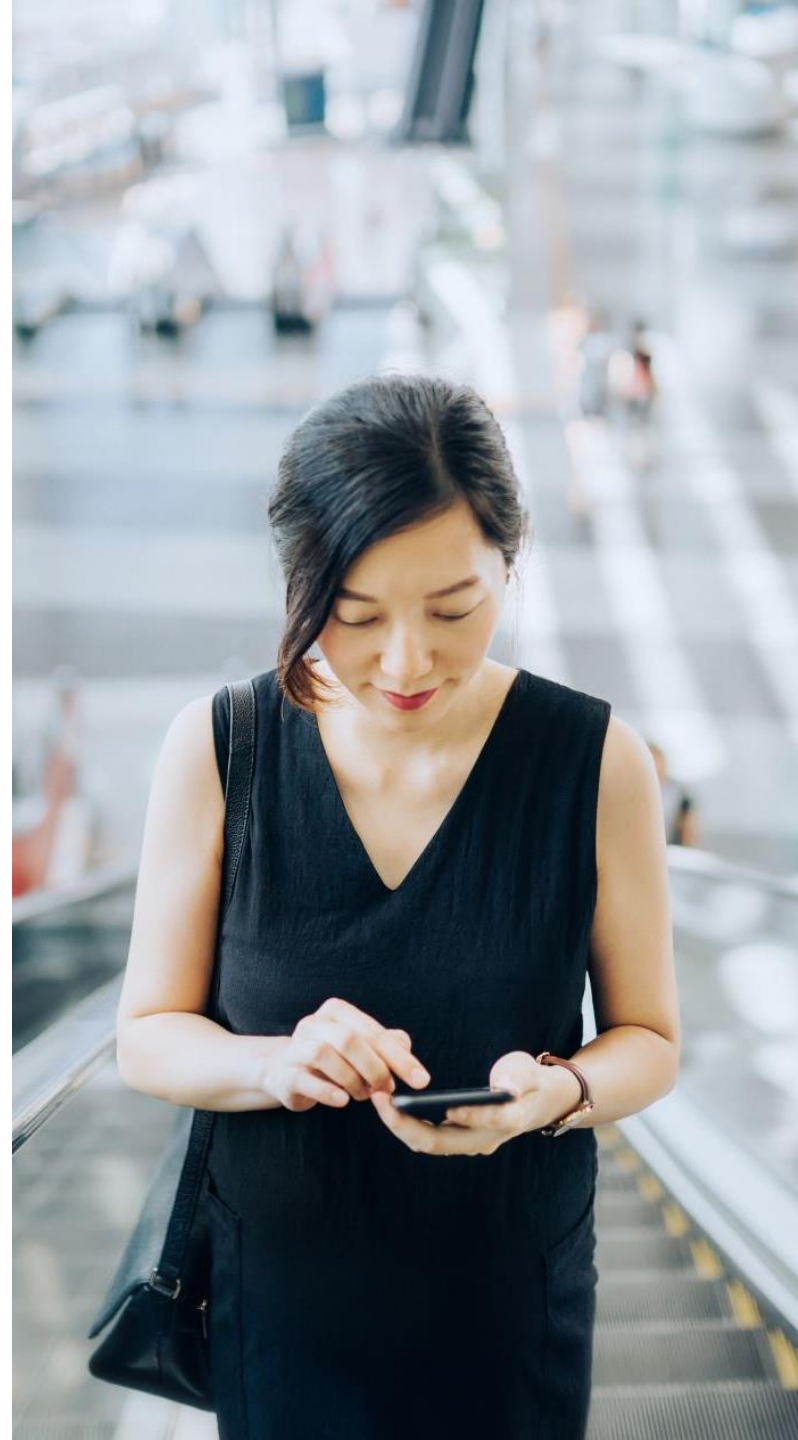


Social Media Listening vs Social Media Tracking

- Social media listening -why your audience says certain things about or related to your brand in SM.
- Social media tracking - how they tell them.
- Social media listening - a great way to track what customers and potential customers have to say about your business, product/service, content, support and more; involves monitoring your brand's social media profiles for customer feedback, direct mentions of your brand, and any conversations with relevant keywords, topics, competitors or industries → then the results are analysed and the findings help determine the best ways to improve your social media strategy, brand awareness and SM presence.
- Social media tracking is often also referred to as social media monitoring. It involves identifying and responding to mentions of the brand (keyword) on social media through comments, direct messages, and more. Social media monitoring is the first step in the process of understanding what audiences think and say about a brand on social media.

Why it is important to be able to listen to SM content

- Carolyn Mae Kim (2016, p.32): “The goal is to identify what conversations are taking place on social media platforms that are relevant to the brand, who is having those conversations, and ways in which the organisation can engage in that dialogue.”
- *Social Media listening* allows you to track, analyse, and respond to conversations about yourself (as an individual, organisation, or product brand) on Social Media channels.
- Tracking conversations on SM is an essential component in audience research and audience targeting.



Social Media listening does not coincide with SM tracking.

Conversation listening takes a broader perspective. It doesn't just look at the numbers; it looks at interpreting the facts/how people think about you, your competition, and the sector you are in.

How? Methods of monitoring conversations

- Keyword monitoring
- Audience screening
- Audience analysis
- Competition monitoring

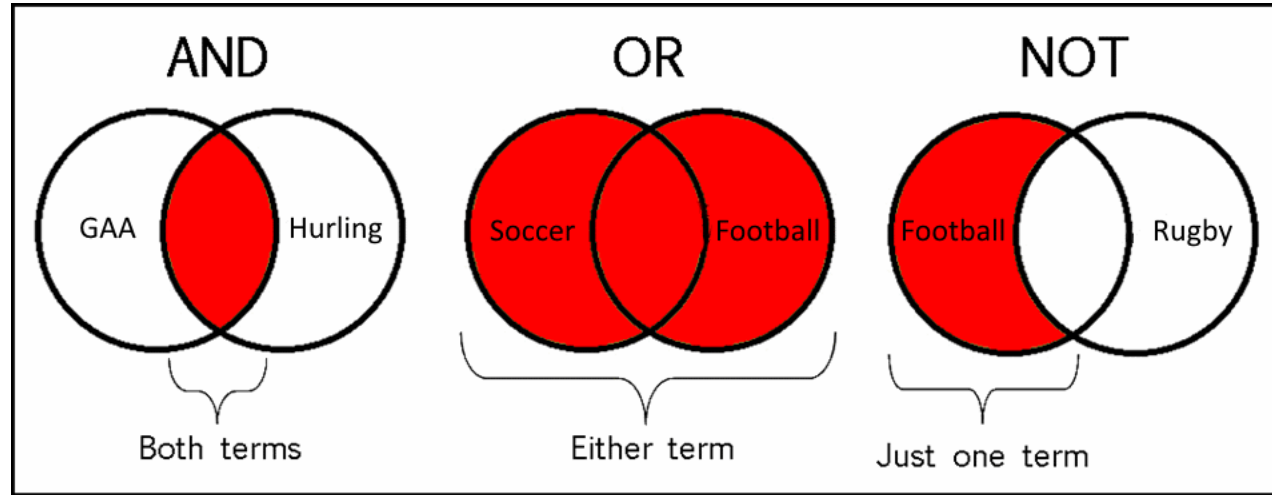
Monitoring keywords

- Identifying words and sentences relevant to your business/organisation/your client
- How do we identify them?
 - Some examples: mentioning the name of the brand/company/person
 - Relevant hashtags
 - mentioning competitors
 - Industry trends
 - statistics

What are people saying about us?

Create an account on Social Searcher and apply:

<https://www.social-searcher.com/>



Boolean search:

- <https://www.meltwater.com/en/blog/boolean-media-monitoring>
- <http://booleanblackbelt.com/2008/12/basic-boolean-search-operators-and-query-modifiers-explained/>

Google Alert:

- <https://ahrefs.com/blog/how-to-set-up-google-alerts/>
- <https://mention.com/en/blog/how-to-set-up-google-alerts/>

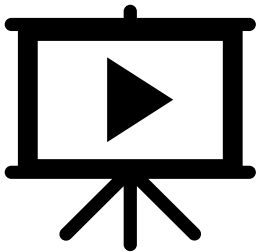
How do we search?

BuzzSumo


Meltwater
Outside Insight

HubSpot

 Hootsuite™



- "Manual" searches
- Using specialized software:
 - <https://www.hootsuite.com>
 - <https://www.meltwater.com/en>
 - <https://www.hubspot.com>
 - <https://buzzsumo.com>



Social Media Monitoring & Listening Apps

- Hootsuite (price: from \$99/month, 30-day demo)
- Sprout Social (price: from \$199/month, 30-day trial)
- HubSpot Marketing Hub (price: from \$792/month, limited free options)
- Brandwatch (price via consultant, solution packages)
- Buffer – (free + plans from \$5)
<https://buffer.com>
- BuzzSumo - (price: from \$199/month different plans and services)
- Mention – price: from \$49/month, trial
- Determ (ex Mediatoolkit) - (price via consultant, solution packages)



Sentiment analysis

- There's so much data posted daily on social media that it can be hard to keep up. Not only do you want to know what's being said about your own business, but you want to know what's being said about your competitors, the industry sector and emerging trends among your customers. You want to be in the know.
- Social media sentiment analysis is the process of interpreting and determining whether text data collected in social media is positive, negative or neutral. This analysis is not limited to simply collecting and counting the number of mentions, comments or hashtags.
- Sentiment analysis doesn't just collect and count mentions, comments, or hashtags. It goes deeper, providing a profound understanding of the attitudes, opinions, and emotions behind the text. For instance, a post collected from Facebook might mention your brand in a positive or negative light 🤔 , offering valuable context beyond mere numbers. This depth of understanding can make you feel more enlightened and knowledgeable about your brand's perception.
- Sentiment analysis gives way to an even deeper analysis of MS mentions. For example, once we know that the predominant underlying sentiment is negative, we can look deeper for causes and take action.

Audience screening - Sentiment scale

Online sentiment scoring - is the assessment of sentiment generated by a keyword, over a period of time.

<https://sproutsocial.com/insights/social-media-sentiment-analysis/>



Sentiment analysing tools (Brandwatch, Talkwalker, Hootsuite Insights, Lexalytics)



<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s00779-019-01361-7>

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/topics/computer-science/sentiment-score>



Uses of sentiment analysis in social media

- Audience insights and changing consumer trends - understanding the audience's thoughts, opinions, perceptions and feelings → we need to keep up; consumer mindsets change over time, as is natural.
- Tracking brand mentions, related products/services, and key people is not just a task; it's a valuable tool → This comprehensive approach builds a solid base for analysis [?], providing reassurance about the effectiveness of our brand positioning strategies.
- Brand reputation analysis over time - an insight into how the public feels about the brand over different time periods → we can track how specific actions affect brand reputation and positioning, e.g., Pepsi & Kendall Jenner (see: <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/04/05/business/kendall-jenner-pepsi-ad.html> OR <https://www.amausf.org/single-post/how-kendall-jenner-caused-millions-in-losses-for-pepsi-with-a-single-advertisement>)



Uses of sentiment analysis in social media

- Comparing our brand image with that of our competitors  is not just a benchmarking exercise. It's a powerful motivator, showing us what we can do to enhance our social media strategy and stay ahead in the game.
- Monitoring brand performance on different SM platforms - comparing the number of brand mentions and analysing sentiment on other channels, → we can see where the brand is performing in the best and worst  ways to improve interaction and engage more with the audience; we see how well a particular social media channel is working or not working for our brand.



Benefits

- (1) analysis of the progress over the years
- (2) an overview of the main progress achieved so far; and
- (3) highlighting outstanding limitations

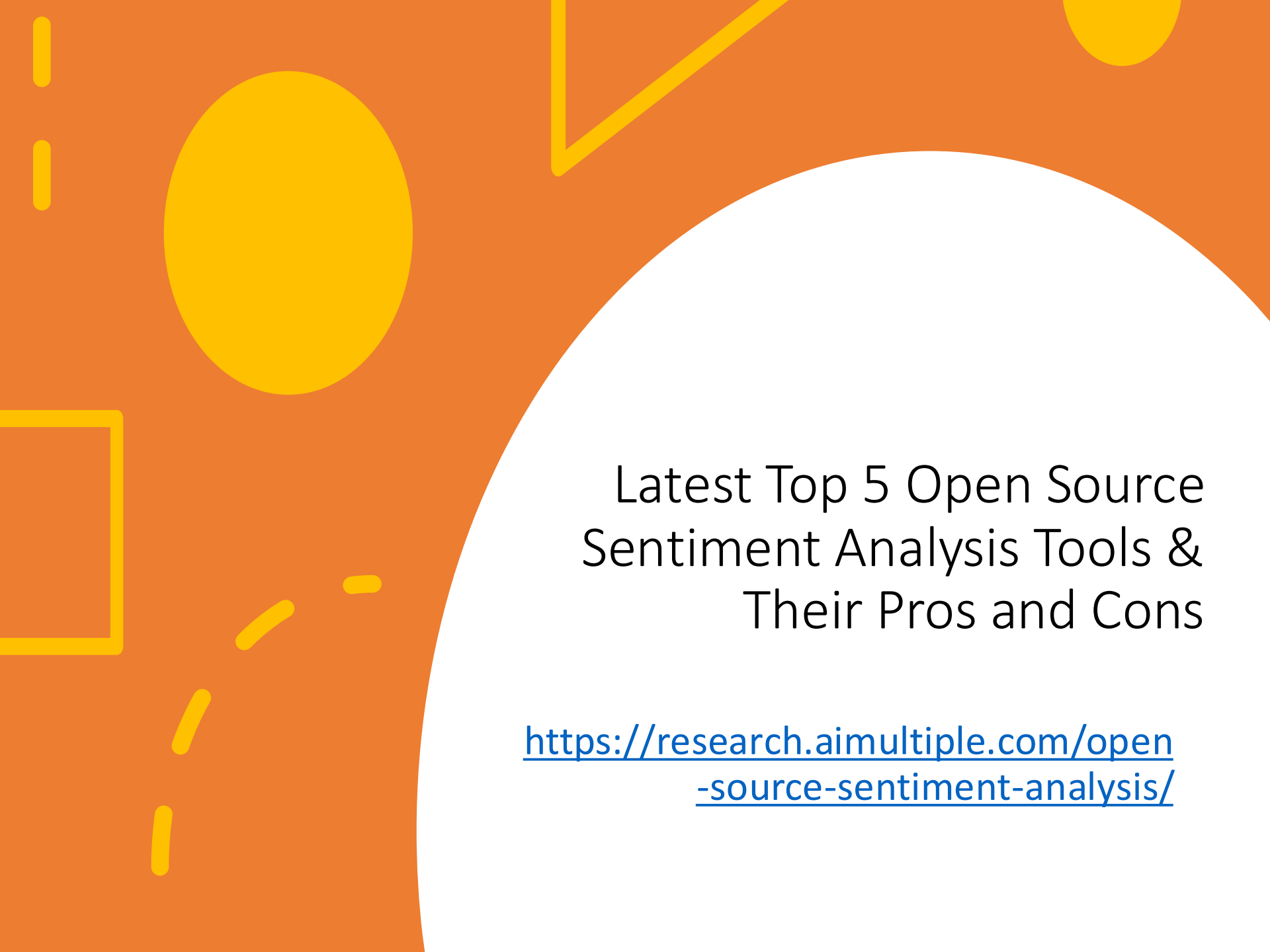
See:

- **Social Media Sentiment Analysis: Tools and Tips for 2025:**
<https://blog.hootsuite.com/social-media-sentiment-analysis-tools/>



Hootsuite Insights Powered by Brandwatch
(<https://youtu.be/wkUngiQISHE?si=npHvxaEx9-ve7WR>)





Latest Top 5 Open Source Sentiment Analysis Tools & Their Pros and Cons

<https://research.aimultiple.com/open-source-sentiment-analysis/>

Audience analysis

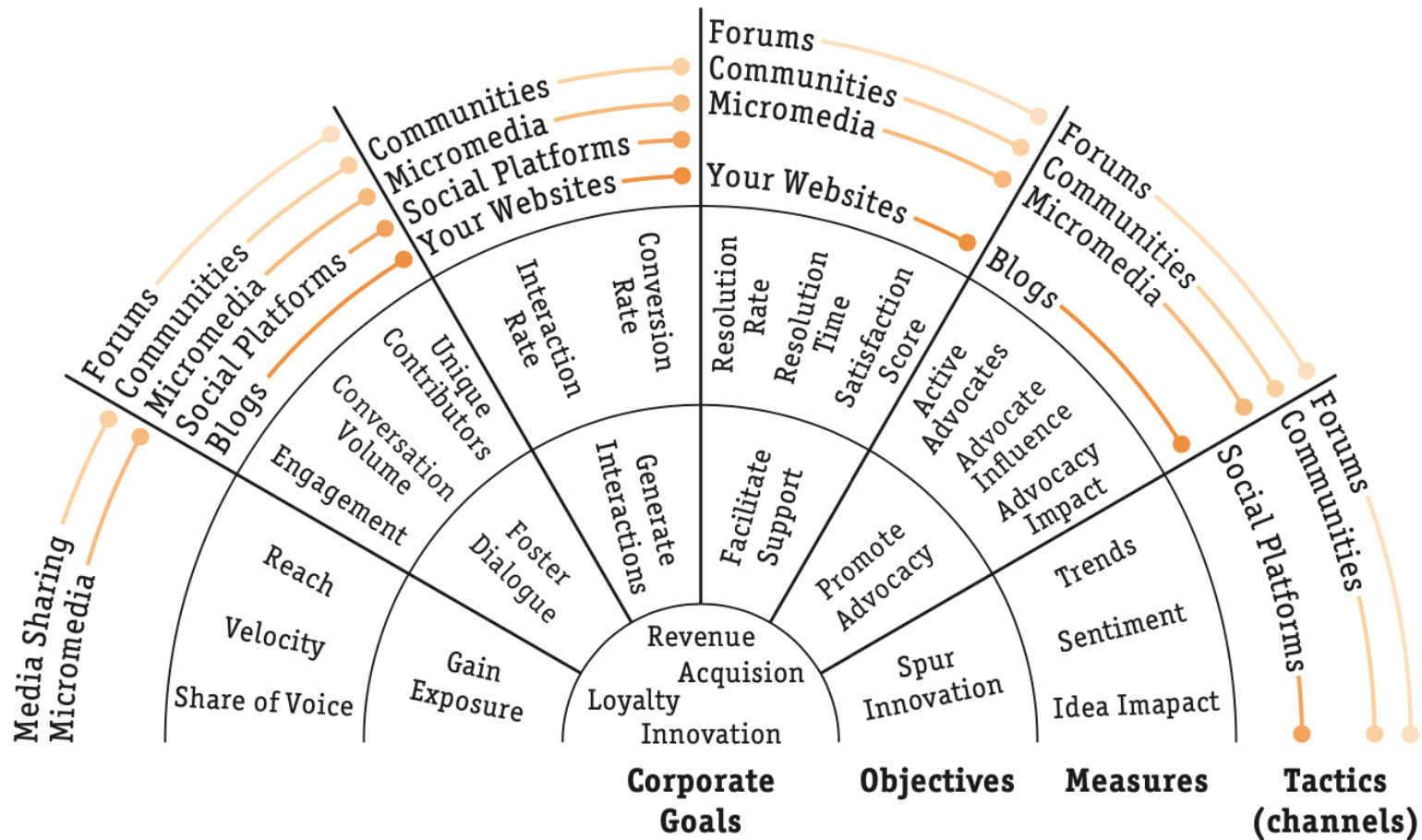
- Setting and identifying audiences - public relations:
- Building an audience persona:
(<https://wiredimpact.com/blog/target-audience-persona-development/#:~:text=What's%20the%20Difference%20Between%20Target,supporters%20on%20a%20personal%20level>)
- *Facebook Insights*:
<https://moz.com/blog/facebook-insights-create-audience-personas-budget>
- <https://blog.hootsuite.com/facebook-analytics-insights-beginners-guide/>
- <https://youtu.be/hemZDcEpjT8>



SOCIAL MEDIA METRICS

Social Media Measurement & Analysis

- Social Media Metrics
- What are we measuring?
 - Number of fans, followers, visitors, views, new and returning visitors, active and inactive users, positive and negative likes, ratings and reviews, downloads and uploads, shares, bookmarks, comments, sentiments, referral keywords, referral sources, influencers, key influencers, etc.
- Indicators: share of voice (relative percentage of brand name mentions compared to competition), audience engagement, conversation reach (presence in conversations or degree of access to conversations with target audience/audience), active advocates, advocate influence, advocacy impact, resolution rate, resolution time, satisfaction score, topic trends, sentiment ratio and idea impact– adapted from Lovett (2011, p. 156)



Owned Media —●—

Earned Media —●—

Note: Goals, Objectives, Measures, and Tactics presented in this framework are examples. Customize these for your organization.

The Social Analytics Framework.

Lovett (2011, p.193)

FOUNDATIONAL MEASURE	CALCULATION
Interaction	$\text{Conversions} / \text{Activity} = \text{Interaction}$
Engagement	$\text{Visits} \times \text{Time} \times \text{Comments} \times \text{Shares} = \text{Engagement}$
Influence	$\text{Volume of Relevant Content} \times \text{Comments} \times \text{Shares} \times \text{Reach} = \text{Influence}$
Advocates	$\text{Influence} \times \text{Positive Sentiment} = \text{Advocacy}$
Impact	$\text{Outcomes} / (\text{Interactions} + \text{Engagement}) = \text{Impact}$

BUSINESS OBJECTIVE KPI	CALCULATION
Reach	$\text{Seed Audience} \times \text{Shared Network Audience} = \text{Reach}$
Velocity	$\text{Reach} \times \text{Time} = \text{Velocity}$
Share of Voice	$\text{Brand Mentions} / \text{Total Mentions (Brand + Competitor A, B, C...n)} = \text{Share of Voice}$

For more indicators and their definition/explanation see Lovett (2011, pp. 161-195)



ROI measurement

<https://blog.hootsuite.com/measure-social-media-roi-business/>



Reach



Audience engagement



Platform traffic



Leads generated



New visitors/ new followers



Lead/ revenue – <https://blog.zoominfo.com/social-media-increase-revenue/>



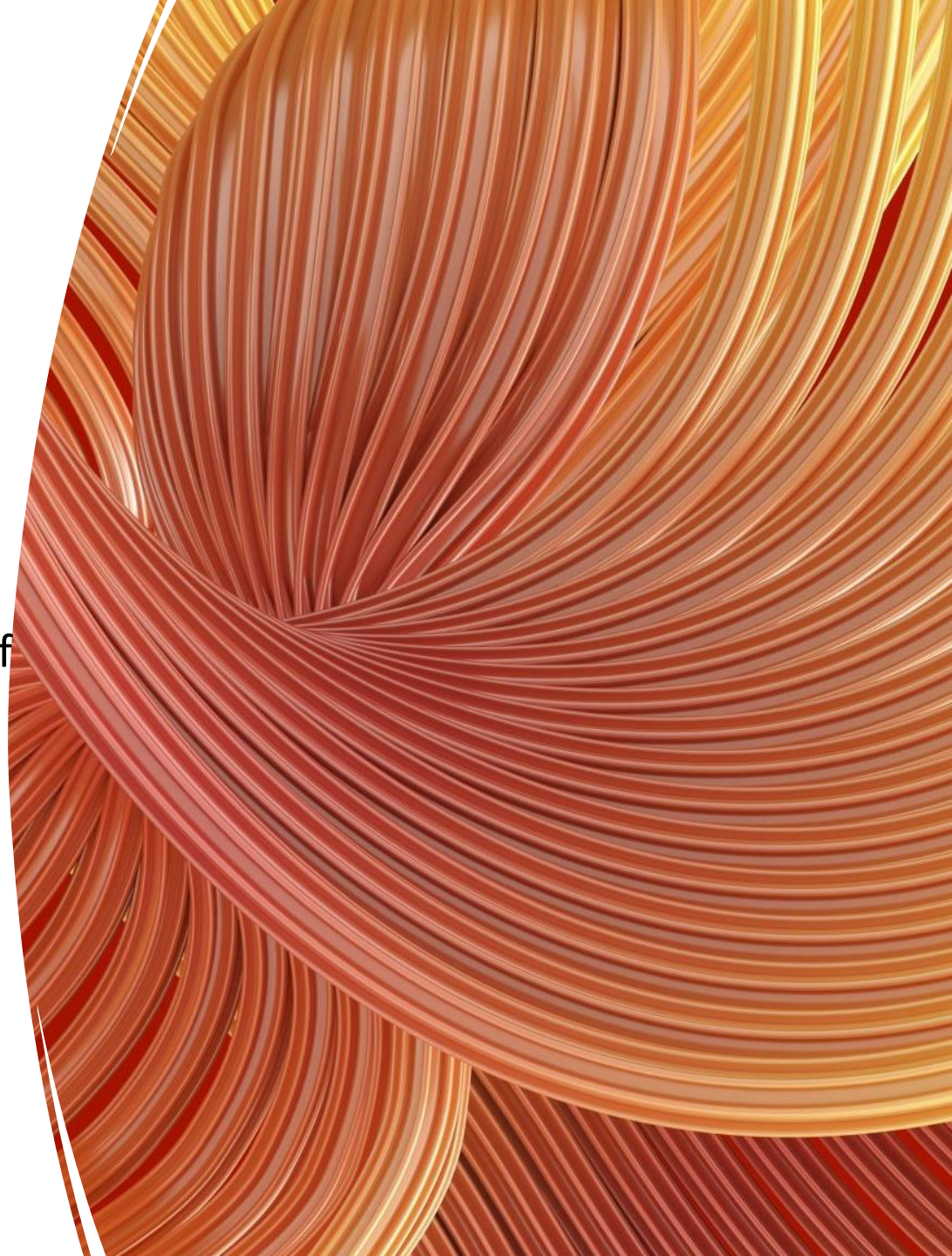
See also:

<https://youtu.be/o35Fs-lk9FA>

Mandatory reading:



Shahbaznezhad, H., Dolan, R., & Rashidirad, M. (2021). The Role of Social Media Content Format and Platform in Users' Engagement Behavior. *Journal of Interactive Marketing*, 53(1), 47-65. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.intmar.2020.05.001>



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inter al.

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